



Active Transportation & the Built Environment

Accessibility, Design, and Planning

Fall 2026

Maryam Hosseini

City & Regional Planning



FOLLOW
THE
WHITE
RABBIT

Follow the White Rabbit!

**Follow the instructions in your
submissions!**

Why should we care about Definitions?

Why Should We Even Care?

"If people are using the terms successfully, why bother to more clearly define them?"

Conflicting definitions cause problems, however, as they affect how people try to create walkable places in practice, measure environmental walkability, and assess the costs and benefits of creating walkable environments. Practitioners and researchers may talk with great conviction about how to make environments more walkable, but **could well be proposing conflicting solutions**. The lack of clarity also makes it difficult to develop a theory to guide practice (Caplan and Nelson, 1973). "

[Forsyth \(2015\)](#)

Defining Walkability - Forsyth

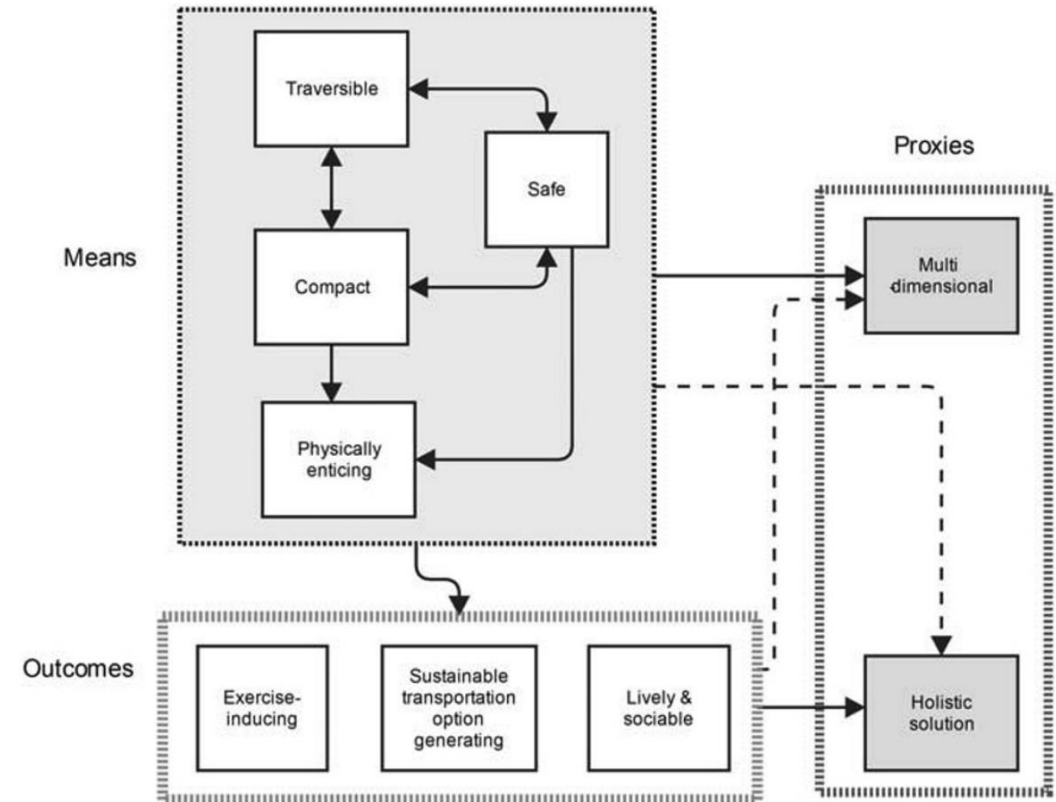
Conditions or Means

Outcomes

For whom?

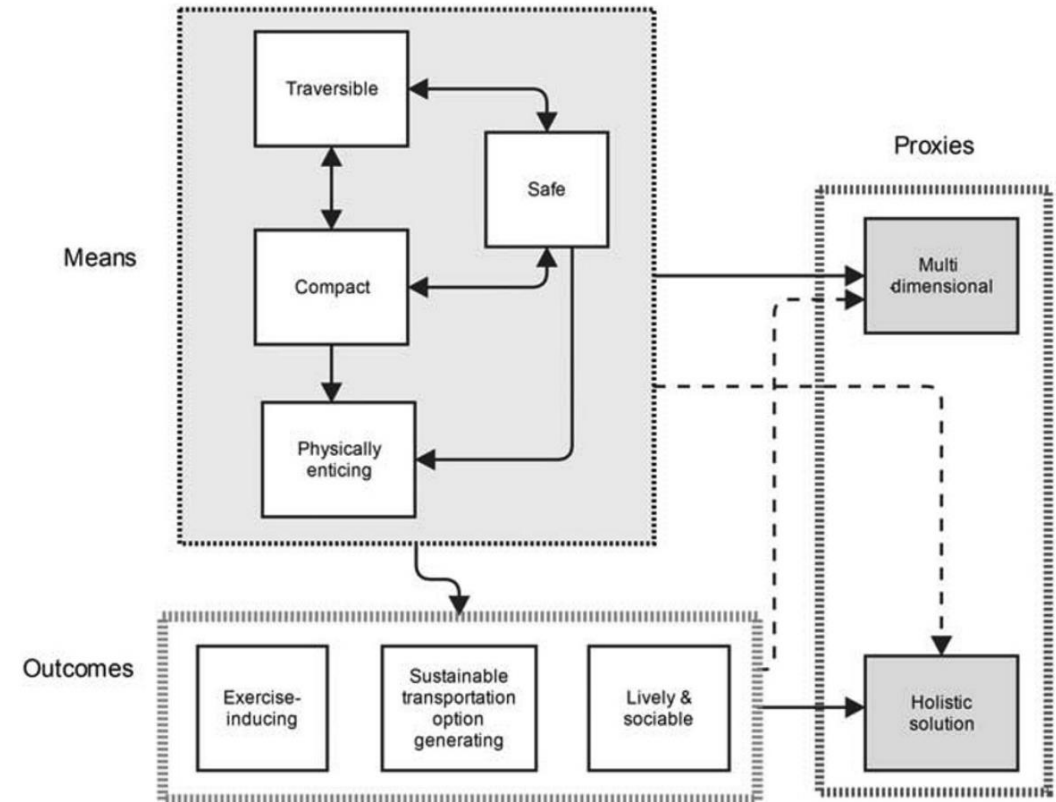


Not included as a
separate category



Defining Walkability - Forsyth

- **Start with core requirements:** Traversable paths, nearby destinations, and basic safety.
- **Use precise terms:** Specify what makes a place walkable, such as compactness or support for exercise.
- **Broaden the definition:** Consider policies, programs, pricing, and **people's needs**, preferences, and perceptions.
- **Recognize tensions:** Different purposes may require different conditions, closeness for errands, longer routes for exercise.



How do you define walkability?

- 1- Write your own definition.
- 2- Pick a definition from one of the papers you've read, that is closest to your idea, and say how that definition refines yours.

Take Home

Due Monday Sep 28

Follow the same process for accessibility, based on the papers you read, and bring your definition to class on Monday.